



P18 · 28 PAGES, AGES 18 MONTHS TO 4 YEARS

## *A Toilet Learning Planner*

*Twenty-eight pages with no "three day" promises.  
Readiness signs, gear checklist, a four-week gentle path,  
accident-day scripts, daycare and grandparent handoff  
pages, regression expectations, and a page for the parent  
who is more stressed than the child.*

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## *Soothemade* Notes

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

## *A note before you start*

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The internet will tell you the family next door got their kid into underwear in three days. The internet is lying, or the family is editing, or the kid was secretly ready three months ago. None of those help you, here, in your kitchen, with your kid.

The honest version is this: toilet learning usually takes a stretch of two to twelve weeks, in waves, with some flat days and some surprising days. The kid leads. The adult mostly cleans. At the end of it, something has shifted that you cannot un-shift, and it is good.

This planner does not promise a method. It offers a pace. It assumes you are paying attention, going at the kid's speed, and willing to wait through the parts that are inconvenient.

Soothemade

*If a pediatric provider has flagged any concerns about your child's toileting, follow their guidance over this planner. This is for typically-developing toddlers in the usual window.*

# The readiness page

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**T**welve signs. You don't need all of them. You want roughly four to six showing up in the same month.

## PHYSICAL

- ☐ Stays dry for two-hour stretches during the day
- ☐ Has predictable poop times (after meals, before nap)
- ☐ Can pull pants up and down with help
- ☐ Walks steadily, can sit on a small chair without tipping

## BEHAVIORAL

- ☐ Tells you (with words or signs) that they're wet or dirty
- ☐ Hides to poop in the diaper (this is a big one)
- ☐ Asks about the toilet, watches you use it, wants to flush
- ☐ Doesn't want a diaper changed, finds it annoying

## SOCIAL

- ☐ Imitates other behaviors at home or daycare
- ☐ Wants to wear underwear "like a big kid"
- ☐ Has a sense of "wet" and "dry" as words
- ☐ Can wait two minutes for something they want

## *A note on age*

The American Academy of Pediatrics says most kids show readiness signs between 18 and 30 months. Some show them at 16 months. Some show them at 36 months. None of those are wrong. There is no medal for being early. There is no penalty for being late.

If you are reading this and your kid is 22 months, you are likely in the window. Wait for four to six readiness signs. Then start.

## *The gear list*

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**D**ecide on these before day one. Buy what you need. Set up your stations.

### *The potty decision*

You have three reasonable options. Pick one.

Option A: A small standalone potty on the floor

Pros: Kid can use it independently, less scary,  
lower commitment for them

Cons: You will empty it. Many times. Each time.

Option B: A toilet-seat reducer + step stool

Pros: No emptying, transitions cleanly to "real"  
toilet, works at other people's houses

Cons: Higher to climb, water sounds, feet need  
the stool

Option C: Both, with the standalone for early days  
and the reducer for later

Pros: Best of both worlds

Cons: Two things to clean

Most families end up at Option C eventually. If you want to start simple, Option A is the gentlest.

### *Underwear*

- Six to twelve pairs. Cheap ones. They will be ruined.

- One size up from what you'd buy for everyday. Easier to pull up.
- Soft elastic at the waist. Anything tight or fancy will be rejected.

## *Pants*

- Loose. Pull-on. No buttons, no zippers, no overalls for the first month.

## *Sheets*

- Mattress protector first, sheet second.
- Sometimes a second mattress protector + sheet layer underneath (so a 2am accident is just a "pull the top layer off and the bed is already made" event).

## *A travel kit*

- A small wet bag, two pairs of underwear, two pairs of pants, a pack of wipes, a change of socks. In the diaper bag, in the car, at grandma's.

## *Cleanup supplies*

- Enzymatic cleaner for accidents. Plain soap and water mostly fine, enzymatic is for the rugs.
- A small designated potty-cleaning brush. Not the same as the household toilet brush.

# The four-week gentle path

A pace, not a method. You can compress it. You can stretch it. The kid will tell you.

## Week one, observation only

Goal: just notice the kid's natural pattern.

What you do:

- Keep them in their usual diapers.
- Watch when they pee and poop. Write it down. Half-hour resolution is enough.
- Talk casually about the bathroom. "I'm going to pee." Nothing big.
- Get the gear set up. Put the potty in the bathroom. Show it. Don't make them sit.

What changes:

- Nothing yet. You are gathering data.

THE OBSERVATION LOG (one row per half-hour, fill in 'D' for dry, 'W' for wet, 'P' for poop, 'X' for nothing notable)

DAY: \_\_\_\_\_

|      |     |       |     |       |     |      |     |      |     |      |     |      |     |
|------|-----|-------|-----|-------|-----|------|-----|------|-----|------|-----|------|-----|
| 7:00 | ___ | 9:00  | ___ | 11:00 | ___ | 1:00 | ___ | 3:00 | ___ | 5:00 | ___ | 7:00 | ___ |
| 7:30 | ___ | 9:30  | ___ | 11:30 | ___ | 1:30 | ___ | 3:30 | ___ | 5:30 | ___ | 7:30 | ___ |
| 8:00 | ___ | 10:00 | ___ | 12:00 | ___ | 2:00 | ___ | 4:00 | ___ | 6:00 | ___ | 8:00 | ___ |
| 8:30 | ___ | 10:30 | ___ | 12:30 | ___ | 2:30 | ___ | 4:30 | ___ | 6:30 | ___ | 8:30 | ___ |

After a week, you'll see the pattern. Most toddlers pee 6 to 10 times a day and poop 1 to 2 times. There's usually a post-meal pattern.

## *Week two, the introduction*

Goal: kid sits on the potty, maybe nothing happens, you celebrate the sitting.

What you do:

- After meals, after wake-up, and at bath time, invite the kid to sit on the potty. No pants. Two minutes.
- Read one short book while they sit. The book is the structure.
- If they get up after thirty seconds, that's fine. The sit was the practice.
- If they pee or poop in the potty, mild celebration. Smile. "You did it." Not a parade.
- If they don't, neutral. "Maybe next time."

What changes:

- A potty visit happens 3-4 times a day.
- The kid is still in diapers between visits.

## *Week three, the underwear days*

Goal: kid in underwear during waking hours, accidents are expected, you stay regulated.

What you do:

- Wake up. Pee on the potty (or try). Then underwear and pants.
- Set a timer for 30 minutes. When it goes off, "potty break." Sit. Read the book.
- Accidents happen, frequently. When they do: neutral voice. "Your body made some pee. Let's get clean."
- No shame. No "we'll have to go back to diapers." No big sigh. Your face does the same face it does when they spill water.
- Diapers for sleep (naps and night). This is normal.

What changes:

- Many accidents. Plan to be home most of week three.
- A few in-the-potty wins. Often around day four or five.
- You will be tired of laundry. This is the worst week.



## *Week four, the spread*

Goal: longer stretches of dry, a couple of short outings, the rhythm settling.

What you do:

- Continue the timer-based potty breaks, but stretch to 45-60 minutes.
- Add short outings (a trip to the corner store, a walk in the park).
- Bring the travel kit. Set the expectation gently. "We are out. If you need to pee, you tell me, and we find a bathroom or go behind a tree."
- Accidents still happen. Less. Still expected.

What changes:

- Most days have one or two accidents instead of five or six.
- Some days have zero. Other days have four. Both are normal.
- Naps move toward dry by the end of week four, sometimes. (Night is months later.)

## *After week four*

You are not done. You have started. The next eight weeks are the consolidation. Some kids land here cleanly. Some have a regression at week five, especially if a sibling arrives or daycare changes. Both are normal.

# The first-three-days log

A specific log for the start of week three (the underwear days). One page per day, three pages total.

DAY \_\_\_\_ OF UNDERWEAR / DATE: \_\_\_\_\_

| ATTEMPTS | OUTCOME | WHERE | NOTE  |
|----------|---------|-------|-------|
| _____    | _____   | _____ | _____ |
| _____    | _____   | _____ | _____ |
| _____    | _____   | _____ | _____ |
| _____    | _____   | _____ | _____ |
| _____    | _____   | _____ | _____ |
| _____    | _____   | _____ | _____ |
| _____    | _____   | _____ | _____ |

OUTCOME KEY: ☐ pee in potty ☐ poop in potty  
☐ pee in pants ☐ poop in pants  
☐ pee + got it just in time  
☐ sat with nothing

WHAT I NOTICED TODAY (about them, about me):

\_\_\_\_\_

ONE PATTERN STARTING TO SHOW:

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

The pattern usually appears on day four or five. You'll see "pee in pants" cluster at the same time each day. That's the time the kid needs a prompted potty visit, fifteen minutes earlier.

# Accident-day scripts

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Six scripts for the moment after an accident. The principle: the face you make matters more than the words.

1.

"It's okay. Bodies are learning. Let's get clean clothes together."

2.

"Pee happens. Let's not be sad about pee."

3.

"Your body made the pee. Your body is also going to learn to tell you sooner. We have time."

4.

"That was an accident. Accidents are part of this. I'm not upset."

5.

"Let's clean up and try again later."

6.

For the parent's internal use, said in your own head:

"This is part of the work. The work is messy. The work is going."

## *What NOT to say*

- "Why didn't you tell me?" (They cannot answer this. The cognitive sequence of "I feel the pee coming" → "I tell the adult" → "I make it to the potty" is the work itself. They didn't tell you because that's the thing being built.)
- "We talked about this." (You did. They still cannot do it consistently. Both of those are true.)
- "You're a big kid now." (The version of them having an accident is not a "big kid" yet. They are a kid in the middle.)
- "If you have another accident I'm putting you back in diapers." (This rarely works as a deterrent. It usually adds shame to a learning process, which slows the learning.)

## *The daycare handoff page*

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**A** one-page brief for the caregiver.

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Hi,

\_\_\_\_\_ is in the early days of toilet learning. The plan is:

#### WHERE WE ARE (today):

- ☐ Underwear in the morning
- ☐ Underwear all day
- ☐ Pull-ups for the morning, underwear after
- ☐ \_\_\_\_\_

#### THEIR SIGNAL FOR NEEDING TO GO

- ☐ They say "potty"
- ☐ They say "\_\_\_\_\_"
- ☐ They get quiet and walk away
- ☐ They squat
- ☐ They have no signal yet (please offer every ~45 minutes)

#### THE ROUTINE WE'VE BUILT

- ☐ Potty break after every meal
- ☐ Potty break before nap, after nap
- ☐ A short book to read while sitting

#### WHAT WE WANT YOU TO DO

- ☐ Offer the potty on the same rhythm above
- ☐ Use neutral language for accidents
- ☐ Send home the wet clothes in the wet bag
- ☐ Do not put them back in diapers without letting us know first

#### THE TRAVEL KIT INCLUDES

- ☐ \_\_\_ pairs of underwear
- ☐ \_\_\_ pairs of pants

- ☐ \_\_\_ pairs of socks
- ☐ A pack of wipes
- ☐ A wet bag
- ☐ \_\_\_\_\_

Thank you for being part of this with us.

\_\_\_\_\_ (parent name + signature)

\_\_\_\_\_



## *The grandparent handoff page*

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**A** separate version, because grandparents often raised their kids differently and may have feelings.

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Dear \_\_\_\_\_,

\_\_\_\_\_ is in the early days of toilet learning. We are going at their pace. A few things that have shifted since you raised us:

1. We don't say "good job!" when they pee. We say "you did it." (The first creates a performance loop. The second names the fact.)
2. We don't punish accidents. Not even with a sigh. The kid is doing real work.
3. We don't ask the kid to clean up their own accident. They're not capable of it yet. We clean up. They might help.
4. We don't use chocolate or sticker charts. You are welcome to disagree. (Our pediatrician suggested neither.)
5. We don't take videos of the kid using the potty to send to the family group chat. Even though they are very cute.

We love that you want to help. The most useful thing is just to follow the rhythm we've set, and to be a calm voice when an accident happens. Your calm voice carries more weight than ours.

Thank you.

\_\_\_\_\_ + \_\_\_\_\_

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# The night phase

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A short page. The night phase is its own thing, often months after daytime.

## *When night usually lands*

The bladder's ability to hold urine for 10-12 hours is mostly hormonal. The hormone (ADH) ramps up at different ages for different kids. Most kids are reliably night-dry between ages 4 and 6. Some are 3. Some are 7. The AAP does not consider it a concern until age 7 or beyond.

## *What you do*

- Diaper or pull-up at night until you see consistent dry diapers in the morning for 1-2 weeks.
- A "no liquids one hour before bed" rule helps marginally. Don't make it a fight.
- Pee right before sleep, every time.
- Mattress protector under the sheet. A second layer if you have it.

## *What you do not do*

- Wake the kid in the middle of the night to use the toilet. (Sometimes recommended online, often counterproductive.)
- Shame a kid for a night accident. The body is doing what it is doing.
- Talk about it in front of other people, ever.

If night dryness has not arrived by age 7, talk to the pediatrician. It is often a small thing that can be looked at.

# Regression expectations

Things that almost always cause a regression. None of these mean you did anything wrong.

| TRIGGER                       | WHAT HAPPENS                        | WHEN IT USUALLY RESOLVES                 |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| New sibling                   | 2-6 weeks of accidents              | 2-4 weeks after baby settles in          |
| Move / new home               | 1-3 weeks of accidents              | Once they know where the new bathroom is |
| Starting school / new daycare | 2-4 weeks of accidents at new place | Once the routine feels safe              |
| A stomach bug or illness      | A week of accidents                 | Once they're well                        |
| A traveling parent            | A few days of accidents             | When the parent is home and stays home   |
| Big stress in the family      | Weeks of inconsistent               | Whenever the stress resolves             |

When a regression happens, do this:

- Acknowledge the bigger thing. "There's been a lot going on. Your body is showing you that."
- Go back to a slightly tighter schedule (50-minute potty breaks instead of 90).
- Do not return to diapers (unless the kid is asking for them, in which case, yes).
- Wait two weeks. The body almost always re-finds the rhythm.

# *The “I’m more stressed than my kid” page*

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**A** page for the parent.

The hardest part of toilet learning, almost universally, is not what the kid is doing. It is what the parent is feeling. The accumulated laundry. The interruptions. The cost of underwear. The internet telling you it should have been done by now. The mother-in-law asking again.

If you are reading this and feeling tight in the chest, here is what to do.

## *One.*

Set the timer for thirty minutes. Get a coffee. Sit. The kid will be fine for thirty minutes. The timer is the structure. The kid will not regress because you sat down.

## *Two.*

Stop reading internet posts about toilet learning. They are not data. They are stories, often heavily edited.

## *Three.*

Plan to be home for week three. Cancel the things you can cancel. Tell the things you can’t cancel that you’re going to be a little quieter that week. Most of the world will not notice.

## *Four.*

Pick one friend you can text “another accident” to, who will not solve it. That friend exists. (If they don’t, message someone you trust with “I’m in the toilet-learning week and I just need someone to say ‘yeah, this is hard’.” Almost everyone will, immediately.)

## *Five.*

The kid is doing the work. You are doing the work. The week is the work. The work ends. The week ends. The kid, eventually, will pee in the potty without you asking, and you will not realize for thirty minutes that the thing you were carrying has been put down.

## The reflection page

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A single page at the back. To be filled in later, whenever it feels right.

*We started toilet learning on \_\_\_\_\_.*

*The day it really clicked was around \_\_\_\_\_.*

*The hardest week was \_\_\_\_\_.*

*The thing I learned about my kid that I did not know before was:*

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

*The thing I learned about myself that I did not know before was:*

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

*If I do this again with another kid, the one thing I will do differently is:*

\_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

# Numbers to keep

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## PEDIATRICIAN

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Number: \_\_\_\_\_

## DAYCARE / PRESCHOOL

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Number: \_\_\_\_\_

## PEDIATRIC THERAPIST (if any)

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Number: \_\_\_\_\_



From [Soothemade Notes](#), a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.





# Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the  
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the  
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

[notes.soothemade.com](https://notes.soothemade.com)

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